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What to sort out before you build your website

Go through it with a pen. Every point you can answer saves a round of emails with your web designer and makes the quote more accurate.

01 What the website has to do

A website without one clear action ends up as a brochure. Pick the one thing you want a visitor to do and build everything around it.

- [ ] Pick the main action: a call, a WhatsApp message, a form, a booking or an order.
- [ ] Write down where clients find you today: referrals, Google, Facebook, Instagram, people walking past. The website has to welcome the people who arrive from there.
- [ ] Describe in two sentences what you do, for whom and where you work.
- [ ] Note the three questions clients ask you most often. The answers belong on the website.

02 How many pages you need

Start from what your client is looking for. A few complete pages help them more than ten half-empty ones.

- [ ] One page is enough when you have one main service, or a few related ones, and mostly want to be contacted.
- [ ] A presentation website with up to five pages (home, services, about, work, contact) fits when each service needs explaining.
- [ ] You need an online store when you want orders and payments to come in through the website.
- [ ] List the languages you need and who will translate.
- [ ] Pick two or three websites you like and write down exactly what you like about them: the structure, the photos, the colours.

03 The texts

Without texts, the design waits. Write them before you start, even as a rough draft. A web designer can shorten and order them, but only you know what you do and how you work.

- [ ] First impression: the business name, one sentence about what you do and what you want the visitor to do.
- [ ] Services: the list, with a sentence or two for each. Add a starting price if you can.
- [ ] About you: who you are, where you work, since when and why someone can trust you.
- [ ] Proof: photos of your work, reviews, certificates. Only real ones, with the consent of the clients who appear.
- [ ] Contact: phone, WhatsApp, email, address and opening hours.
- [ ] Footer: the company's legal name, tax ID and registered office.

04 Photos and logo

Good photos do more for a website than any effect. Gather them early, as original files.

- [ ] Photos at least 2000 px on the long side, as JPG or PNG. Avoid screenshots and photos sent over WhatsApp, which compresses them.
- [ ] Only photos you have the right to use. Don't take them from Google or other people's websites. People who appear in them must agree.
- [ ] The logo as a vector file (SVG, PDF, AI or EPS). If you don't have one, a PNG with a transparent background, as large as possible.
- [ ] Your brand colours with their codes (for example #D7141E), or a printed piece they can be taken from.

05 Domain, hosting and accounts

The domain and the hosting should be in your company's name, in your own accounts, with the web designer working in them as a guest. That way the website stays yours, whoever builds it.

- [ ] Register the domain (your-company.ro) to your company, with an email address you read. Codes and renewal notices go there.
- [ ] Hosting is the server the website lives on. Open that account in your company's name too. Where the provider allows it, invite your web designer as an administrator instead of sharing your password.
- [ ] If you already use email on your domain (name@your-company.ro), say so before anyone changes the domain settings, so it keeps working.
- [ ] Turn on two-step sign-in for the domain and hosting accounts.

06 Who updates it after launch

Decide at the start whether you want to change texts, photos or products yourself. It decides what kind of website you need.

- [ ] To edit it yourself you need an admin panel, for example WordPress. It needs paid hosting and regular updates.
- [ ] If you change it rarely, a static website loads faster, can run on free hosting and has no plugins to update. Each change goes through your web designer.
- [ ] For a store, decide who uploads products, who handles orders and who deals with returns.

07 What you pay every year

The website itself is a one-off payment. A few costs come back every year. Ask for them in writing before you start.

Domain	Every year. Ask for the renewal price, not just the first year's.
Hosting, static website	Can be free, for example on Cloudflare's free plan.
Hosting, WordPress website	About €50–70 a year.
Hosting, WooCommerce store	About €80–150 a year.
Email on your domain	Separate from the website, usually paid per address.
Card payments (store)	A fee on each transaction, charged by the payment provider.
Maintenance	Updates, backups and small changes. Monthly or on request.

08 What to ask a web designer before you pay

- [ ] Whose name are the domain and the hosting in?
- [ ] What will I pay every year after launch?
- [ ] What is included in the price and what costs extra?
- [ ] How many rounds of changes do I get, and what counts as a round?
- [ ] Who writes the texts?
- [ ] Can I change texts and photos myself?
- [ ] When does the delivery time start, and what can delay it?
- [ ] How do I pay: deposit, on delivery, in instalments?
- [ ] What do I get at handover: access, files, instructions?
- [ ] If I want to work with someone else in a year, can I take the website with me?

When you're ready

I build presentation websites and online stores for companies and sole traders, from Timișoara. I work alone, so you talk to the person who designs, builds and launches your website. Send me your answers from this guide and I'll tell you which option fits and what it costs.

Presentation website from €300 · Online store from €600

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